

Unconditional Cash Transfers to Women (UCTW)

Group B Policy Analysis

(Policy Deconstruction Assignment)

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Group's Policy Position

OPPOSE

Fundamentally flawed, fiscal,
administrative and opportunity costs
outweigh the policy's benefits

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What the policy is

- Unconditional Cash Transfers to Women (UCTW) are recurring, monthly, Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) payments made by state governments to adult women
- Delivery runs on India's JAM infrastructure (Jan Dhan accounts, Aadhaar authentication, mobile-linked DBT)

Objectives

- Financial self-reliance
- Dignity & Recognition
- Income security
- Health & nutrition etc.

Eligibility

Varies in States (nominal to none)

- Permanent Resident
- Age
- Income Ceiling
- Electricity consumption etc.

Scale

- Operational in 12 states
- Approx. 1.7 lakh cr per year

State-wise scheme

Scheme, eligibility, monthly benefit and budget provision (BE 2025-26) by state

Himachal Pradesh (HP)

Indira Gandhi Pyari Behna Sukh Samman Nidhi Yojana | Phased roll-out, 18-59 yrs

Rs 1,500 /month | Rs 138 crore

Haryana (HR)

Lado Laxmi Yojana | Women 18+

Rs 2,100 /month | Rs 5,000 crore

Delhi (DL)

Mahila Samridhhi Yojana | Not specified

Rs 2,500 /month | Rs 5,110 crore

Maharashtra (MH)

Mukhyamantri Majhi Ladki Bahin Yojana | 21-65 yrs

Rs 1,500 /month | Rs 36,000 crore

Karnataka (KA)

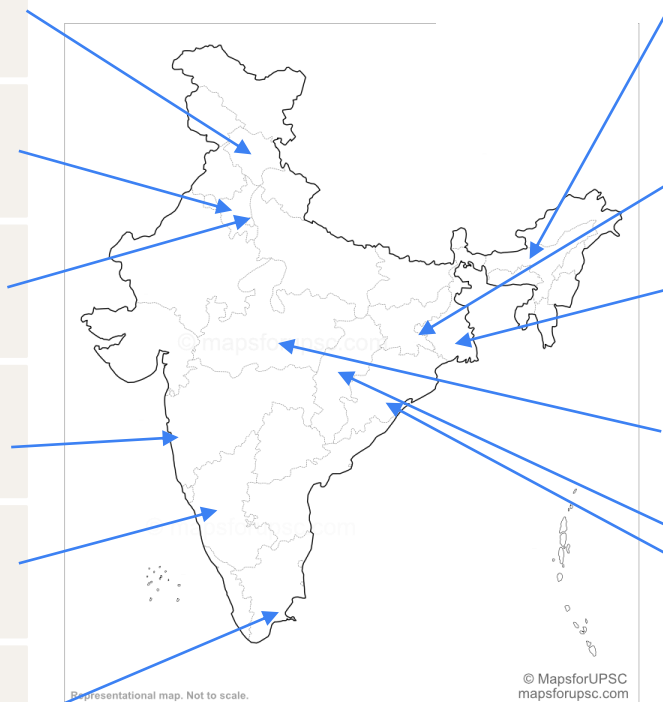
Gruha Lakshmi Yojana | Not specified

Rs 2,000 /month | Rs 28,608 crore

Tamil Nadu (TN)

Magalir Urimai Thogai | 21 yrs and above

Rs 1,000 /month | Rs 13,807 crore



Assam (AS)

Orunodoi Scheme | Women 18+

Rs 1,250 /month | Rs 5,000 crore

Jharkhand (JH)

CM Maiyan Samman Yojana | 18-50 yrs

Rs 2,500 /month | Rs 13,363 crore

West Bengal (WB)

Lakshmir Bhandar Scheme | 25-60 yrs

Rs 1,000-1,200 /month | Rs 26,700 crore

Madhya Pradesh (MP)

Mukhyamantri Ladli Behna Yojana | 21-60 yrs

Rs 1,250 /month | Rs 18,669 crore

Chhattisgarh (CG)

Mahtari Vandan Yojana | Married women 21+

Rs 1,000 /month | Rs 5,500 crore

Odisha (OD)

Subhadra Scheme | 21-60 yrs

Rs 833 /month | Rs 10,145 crore

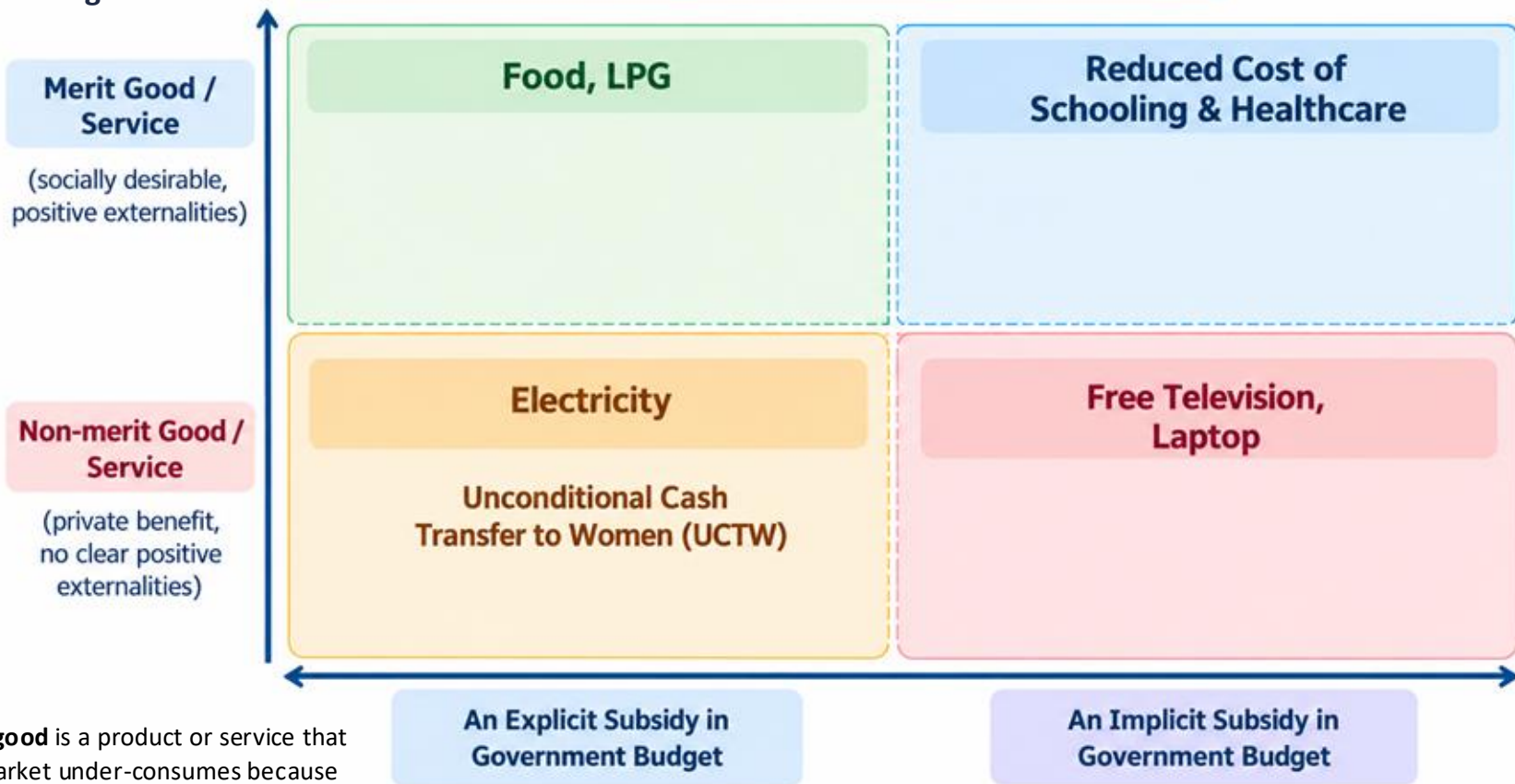
Why we oppose UTCW ?

1. High Fiscal Cost- 12 states have cumulatively spent 1.7 lakh cr (0.5% of GDP) in 2025-26. 6 of the 12 states have revenue deficit. Unconditional transfers have led to fiscal pressure.
2. No economic justification for government intervention. There is no market failure. There is no credible positive externality of meaningful size.
3. It is a politically convenient instrument substituting for capital investment and structural reforms in health, education, which is a merit good. Rather UTCW is political preference rather than a necessity
4. UCTW is better understood as government failure.
5. Weak State Capacity - JAM gives strong capacity (digital infrastructure) to transfer cash at scale but low administrative capacity for accurate targeting, verification and monitoring.
6. Outcomes are overstated- income support rather than women welfare or economic development.

Unconditional cash is
not a merit good.

Understanding Freebies

(Classification of Subsidies)



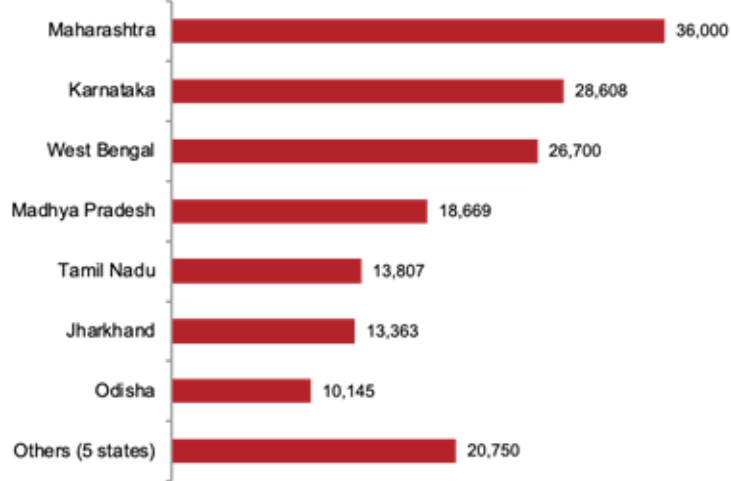
A **merit good** is a product or service that a free market under-consumes because people do not fully realize its long-term benefits

Projected Outcomes

Short-term welfare relief but long-term growth supporting transformation is unproven

Fiscal outcomes

Budget provision by state, BE 2025-26 (Rs crore)



- It is high revenue expenditure & creates no durable asset
- Risk widening deficits
- Partly debt-financed rather than funded entirely from current receipts
- Assam and West Bengal raised allocations 31% and 15% in a year

Administrative outcomes (Maharashtra example)

- Strong infrastructure, weaker implementation
- **Beneficiary correction** - Issues with identifying the right beneficiaries, about 38% of the scheme's 2.46 crore rolls were removed. Linked to KYC failure and other criterias
- **Financial Management problem**- spent ₹33,237 crore against an authorised budget of ₹29,693 crore
- A strong banking infrastructure, or the capacity to move money (Aadhaar, DBT, UPI) is not sufficient

Projected Outcomes

Welfare outcomes

- Short-term consumption smoothing, the spend is on more on food and women has some control over small purchases.
- Weak: bargaining power, labour participation, productivity, intergenerational gains.
- Risks: capture by male relatives; less incentive to stay in low-paid formal work.
- Better described as consumption support than transformative welfare.

Political Outcomes

- Once introduced, a transfer of this kind becomes politically costly to withdraw or even freeze
- West Bengal illustrates the expansion side: competing parties contested how much further to raise Lakshmir Bhandar/Annapurna Bhandar payments rather than whether to retain the scheme
- Maharashtra: will not attempt to recover funds already paid to the roughly 86 lakh ineligible beneficiaries due to fear of the political cost

The real trade-off is between short-term welfare relief and long-term, growth-supporting investment. Do the benefits outweigh the costs?

Evidence

Cash helps, but empowerment needs more

1. Issues with Access and Targeting

92 Lakh

Names removed after verification
(38% of peak enrollment) [\[1\]](#)

62 lakh: incomplete eKYC

16 lakh: above income cap
~29,000 men: ineligible [\[1\]](#)

Unverified beneficiaries already
received Rs. 14000 crore [\[1\]](#)

Pune survey: ~30% women [\[1\]](#) nregistered.

~30% of registrants lacked full
payments [\[2\]](#)

2. Household benefits

A study found higher calorie intake among
mothers and children in Jharkhand
trial due to UCTW.

**But trial found no average improvement
in child growth indicators. [\[3\]](#)**

3. Economic Agency

Own account wage deposits plus
importantly banking training
Increases women's work,
according to the study. [\[4\]](#)

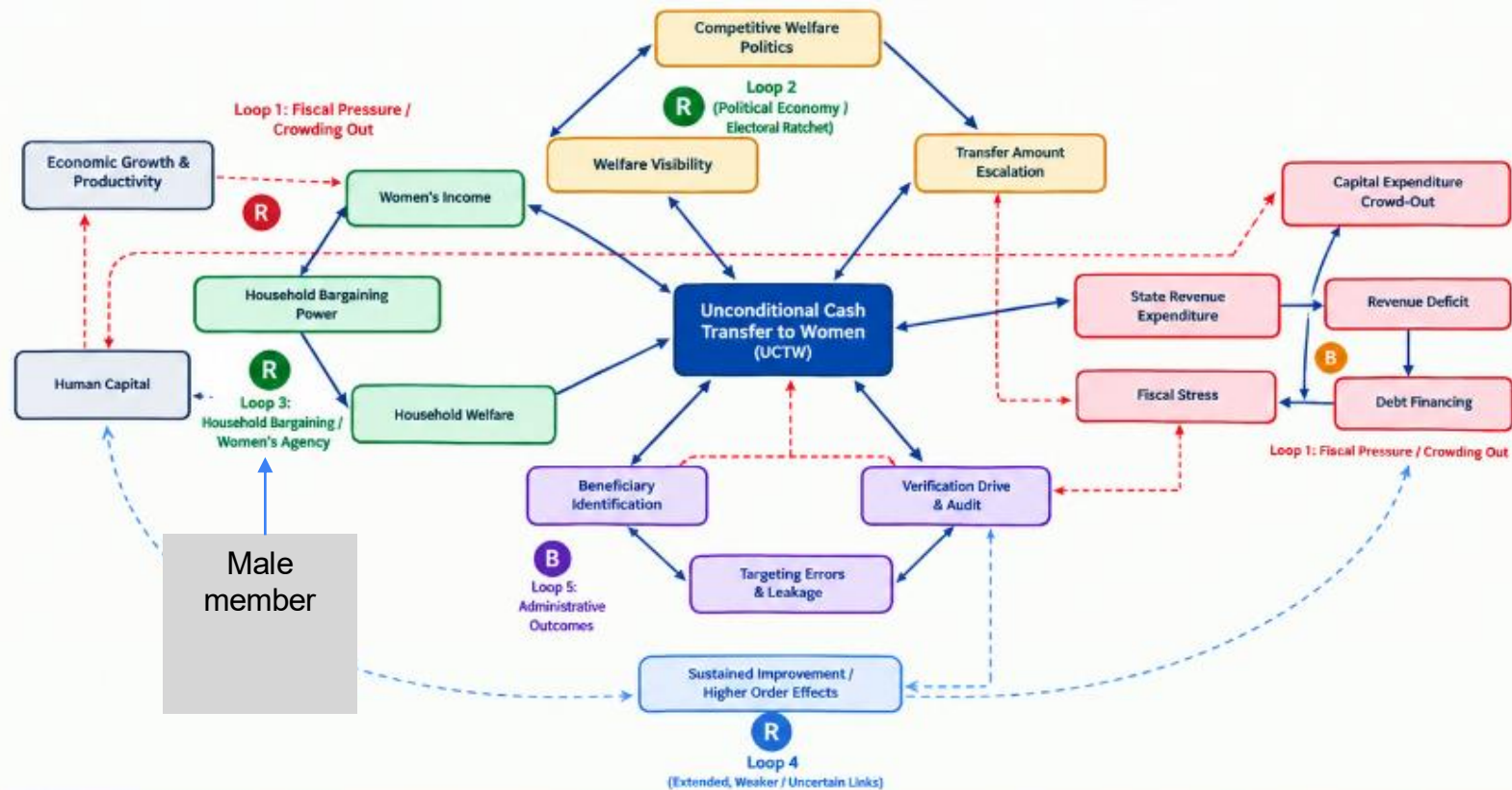
Compared with accounts alone.

UCTW expenditure = ₹1.68,040 crore

MCPF = 3 (Shah and Kelkar)

Social cost = ₹1.68,040crore × 3 = ₹5,04,120 crore

CAG's state finance audits warn that high committed expenditure and subsidies constrain states' fiscal Space, limiting funds for development and increasing fiscal sustainability risk.



Loop colours

- 1 Fiscal pressure / crowding out
- 2 Political economy / electoral ratchet
- 3 Women's agency / household bargaining
- 4 Higher order / sustained improvement
- 5 Administrative outcomes

Causal link



Other symbols



Scenario Matrix 1: Fiscal space × Administrative capacity

Fiscal space → Administrative capacity ↓	Abundant Fiscal Space	Constrained Fiscal Space
High capacity	Scalable welfare system	Efficient prioritisation
Low capacity	High spending, weak delivery	Minimal/fragile delivery

Fiscal space: Does the state have enough money/budget room?

Administrative capacity: Can the state identify beneficiaries, deliver payments, monitor, and correct errors?

1. Scalable welfare system: the state can expand UCTW while maintaining accurate targeting and payments.

2. Efficient prioritisation: the state may maintain essential transfers but tighten eligibility or prioritise the most vulnerable

3. High spending, weak delivery: a large UCTW budget but many ineligible beneficiaries, leakage, or weak verification, as illustrated by the Maharashtra case in your brief

4. Minimal/fragile delivery: transfers may be small, irregular, narrowly targeted, or difficult to administer, producing limited welfare coverage

Scenario Matrix 2: Fiscal space × Economic Opportunity

Fiscal space → Economic Opportunity ↓	Abundant Fiscal Space	Constrained Fiscal Space
Strong Economic Opportunity	Empowerment & Transformation	Productive but Constrained
Weak Economic Opportunity	Welfare Security Trap	Fiscal & Welfare Stress

Economic Opportunity: Does the surrounding economy give women real avenues (jobs, credit, enterprise) to convert additional income into lasting economic gains?

Abundant fiscal space + strong economic opportunity: state can maintain transfers without severely crowding out other public expenditure, while the economy provides women with opportunities to use additional purchasing power productively.

Abundant fiscal space + weak economic opportunity: The government can afford the transfers, but the economy does not provide sufficient productive opportunities.

Constrained fiscal space + strong economic opportunity: Women may have genuine opportunities to work, save, invest or start enterprises, but the state faces difficulty maintaining a large recurring transfer programme.

Constrained fiscal space + weak economic opportunity: Government faces fiscal pressure **at the same time that women have few alternative economic opportunities**.

Scenario Matrix 3: Fiscal space × Political-Competitive Intensity

Fiscal space → Political-Competitive Intensity ↓	Abundant Fiscal Space	Constrained Fiscal Space
Low / Consensus	Sustainable Welfare Consolidation	Fiscal Discipline & Targeting
High / Escalating	Competitive Welfare Expansion	Populist Fiscal Squeeze

Political-Competitive Intensity: How strongly do competing parties contest women's welfare generosity as an electoral issue, pushing transfer amounts and coverage upward regardless of the state's underlying fiscal capacity?

Abundant fiscal space + Low political competition: State has sufficient fiscal capacity to maintain the programme, while political competition is relatively low. There is broad acceptance of UCTW across major political actors.

Constrained fiscal space + Low political competition: Political actors are not aggressively competing to expand the programme, but the government faces fiscal constraints.

Abundant fiscal space + High political competition: There is enough fiscal capacity to finance transfers **and** strong electoral incentives to expand them.

Constrained fiscal space + High political competition: This is the most difficult scenario. Government faces **two opposing pressures simultaneously**: Fiscal constraints → pressure to reduce expenditure but Electoral competition → pressure to maintain/increase visible benefits.

Objectives ↓ / Outcomes →	Outcome 1 (Poverty reduction)	Outcome 2 (Increase in women agency/autono my)	Outcome 3 (Fiscal burden/load)	Outcome 4 (Household welfare) Second order effect	Outcome 5 (Intergenerational upliftment) Third order effect
Objective 1 (Economic empowerment/livelihood)	NA	+	--	0 and -	?
Objective 2 (Poverty alleviation)	++	NA	- -	+	?
Objective 3 (Health & nutrition improvement)	NA	NA	--	+	?
Objective 4 (Recognition & Dignity)	NA	+	-	+	?
Objective 5 (Electoral mobilisation:	NA	++	-	+	?

Legend: ++ Strong positive relationship | + Positive relationship | 0 No clear relationship | - Negative relationship | -- Strong negative relationship | NA Not applicable/not assessed | ? Evidence uncertain/not established

Discussion: Policy alignment with broader national priorities

Macroeconomic stability: An additional ₹1.7 lakh crore added annually to state fiscal deficits works directly against the government deficit discipline that anchors India's macro-fiscal credibility with the RBI and bond markets.

Economic Growth (GDP and GDP per capita): Recurring revenue expenditure of this scale structurally competes with capital expenditure within the same state budgets. Every rupee spent on a recurring transfer is a rupee unavailable for infrastructure, health systems, or skilling investment.

Managing inequality and poverty: Short-term poverty and consumption-volatility relief is real, but it is also an expensive way to deliver it, since eligibility typically rests on a self-declared income ceiling rather than verified need.

Welfare and development: The policy delivers welfare in the narrow sense of consumption support, but "welfare and development" as a national priority implies durable capability-building, not recurring income maintenance.

Viksit Bharat: India's developed-nation ambition requires sustained public capital formation and rising productivity, not an expanding base of recurring entitlement spending that is structurally difficult to reverse.

Remark: UCTW's net contribution is either negative or, at best, narrowly and expensively positive. No single benchmark shows the clear, strong alignment that would justify a recurring expenditure commitment of this scale.

Recommendations:

1. Do not expand existing schemes or introduce new ones in states that have not yet adopted UCTW.
2. Freeze transfer amounts and tighten eligibility immediately in existing schemes, using the verification methodology.
3. Redirect freed fiscal space toward instruments with a genuine market failure to correct: public health and nutrition services, girls' secondary-education retention, vocational skilling linked to verified labor demand, and childcare infrastructure.
4. Commission an independent, pre-registered evaluation of at least two major schemes before any further expansion is considered.
5. Legislate a sunset-and-review clause into any transfer that continues, requiring explicit legislative re-authorisation on a fixed cycle based on the independent evaluation
6. Mandate a standardised, comparable annual CAG-style audit of every state UCTW scheme, published on a common template

Challenges and Anticipated Resistance:

- Political competition over welfare and "freebie" schemes
- Public resistance from current beneficiaries
- Finance departments are a likely ally rather than an obstacle
- The "no market failure" claim will itself be contested

Appendix

States	Name of the scheme	Eligibility Criteria	Benefit (Rs per month)	Budget Provision (BE 2025-26, in Rs crore)
Assam	Orunodoi Scheme	Women over the age of 18 years	1,250	5,000
Chhattisgarh	Mahtari Vandan Yojana	Married women over the age of 21	1,000	5,500
Delhi	Mahila Samriddhi Yojana	-	2,500	5,110
Himachal Pradesh	Indira Gandhi Pyari Behna Sukh Samman Nidhi Yojana	Phased roll-out on the basis of beneficiaries - 18 to 59 years	1,500	138
Haryana	Lado Laxmi Yojana	Women over the age of 18 years	2,100	5,000
Jharkhand	CM Maiyan Samman Yojana	18-50 years	2,500	13,363
Karnataka	Gruha Lakshmi Yojana	-	2,000	28,608
Maharashtra	Mukhyamantri Majhi Ladki Bahin Yojana	21-65 years	1,500	36,000
Madhya Pradesh	Mukhyamantri Ladli Behna Yojana	21-60 years	1,250	18,669
Odisha	Subhadra Scheme	21-60 years	833	10,145
Tamil Nadu	Magalir Urimai Thogai	21 years and above	1,000	13,807
West Bengal	Lakshmir Bhandar Scheme	25-60 years	1,000 - 1,200	26,700

Step 1: Objectives (Stated & Unstated)

- **Economic empowerment / financial self-reliance** Ladli Behna (MP), Gruha Lakshmi (Karnataka), Ladki Bahin (Maharashtra), Maiya Samman (Jharkhand), Subhadra (Odisha), Lado Lakshmi (Haryana), Mahtari Vandan (Chhattisgarh), Lakshmir Bhandar/Annapurna Bhandar (West Bengal)
- **Poverty alleviation / support for economically weaker households** Griha Aadhar (Goa), Orunodoi (Assam), Lakshmir Bhandar/Annapurna Bhandar (West Bengal)
- **Health and nutrition improvement** Ladli Behna (MP), Mahtari Vandan (Chhattisgarh), Ladki Bahin (Maharashtra) — all three name health/nutrition explicitly in their stated objective, alongside economic self-reliance
- **Recognition/compensation for unpaid domestic and care work** Kalaingar Magalir Urimai Thogai (Tamil Nadu) — this is the primary stated framing for this scheme specifically, per Kotiswaran's research Notable: Mahtari Vandan (Chhattisgarh) also touches this via "decision-making role within the family," though economic self-reliance is its lead framing
- **Dignity / social standing of women** Lakshmir Bhandar/Annapurna Bhandar (West Bengal) — "financial support and dignity" is explicit in scheme framing Notable: Gruha Lakshmi (Karnataka) mentions "strengthen women socially" alongside its economic framing
- **Enterprise/livelihood generation (distinct from consumption support)** Mukhyamantri Mahila Rozgar Yojana (Bihar) — the only scheme framed around business creation ("seed money") rather than recurring income support
- **No specific stated objective beyond general UCT framing** Lakshmi Yojana (Delhi) — official description available so far frames it generically as a UCT, without a distinct stated goal like health, dignity, or care-work recognition

Unstated Objective- Electoral mobilisation of women voters ahead of a specific election

Step 2: Stakeholders

1. Women beneficiaries
2. Political executive- Chief Minister, State Cabinet, Political leadership
3. Finance Department
4. Implementing department- Women & Child Development, Social Welfare, Rural Development etc.
5. Administration and local Government- District administration, Panchayats, ULBs, Local officials
7. Payment & Financial Infrastructure- Treasury/Banks/DBT
8. SHGs/NGOs/CSOs
9. Taxpayers and future taxpayers

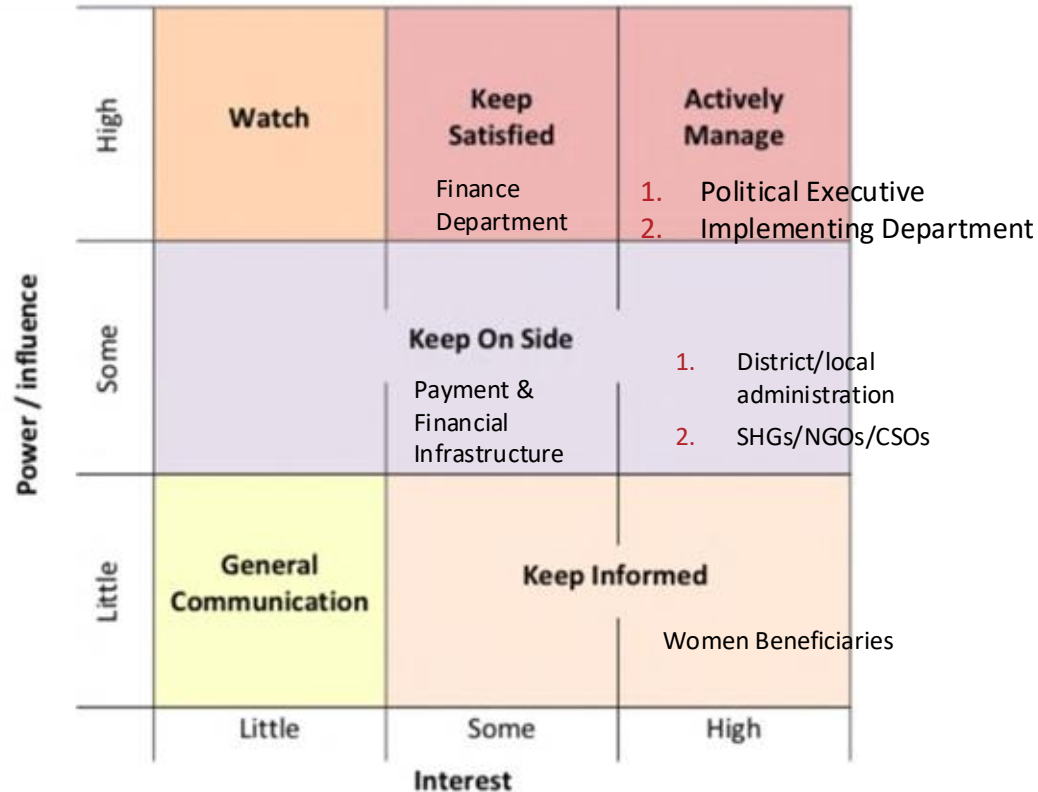
Concerns, Interests and Incentives of relevant stakeholders

Stakeholder	Concerns	Interests	Incentives
Women Beneficiaries	Eligibility-related exclusions, issues in understanding the process/documentation, access to the bank account, delays in payment or failure, inflation, control over money	Assured monthly income, security, ability to meet household expenses	Financial benefit, dignity, autonomy, financial empowerment
Political Executive- Chief Minister, State Cabinet, Political leadership	Financial commitment, high expectations of the beneficiaries, chances of failure, public response, criticism	Women's welfare, political gains/votes, visibility of the programme, public confidence, financial inclusion	1. Expansion of voter base 2. Accountability to their voters/public 2. Credibility of govt. programme
Finance Department	Budget for continuous financial expenditure, sustainability, and managing expenditure priorities	Budget forecast, allocation of resources, accurate beneficiary estimates, financial sustainability	Efficient allocation of government resources
Implementing Department – Women & Child Development, Social Welfare, Rural Development etc.	Identification of the Standard Operating Procedure, coordination problems with departments, database errors, high number of grievances, payment failures	Accessibility to all eligible beneficiaries, smooth and stakeholder-friendly operations, reliable records, awareness, timely payments	1. Efficient programme performance 2. Delivery of mandate 3. Institutional credibility

Concerns, Interests and Incentives of relevant stakeholders

Stakeholder	Concerns	Interests	Incentives
District/local administration – District administration, Panchayats, ULBs, local officials	Limited capacity of the officials, coordination issues with departments & stakeholders, validation of the eligible beneficiary, disputes, complaints regarding the payments, lack of awareness	User-friendly implementation, high coverage of beneficiaries, accurate database, timely payments	Efficient administrative performance
Payment & Financial Infrastructure- Treasury/Banks/DBT	Failed transactions, KYC/account issues, incorrect or duplicate payments, delays in processing, accounting errors	Reliable payments, high success rate for transactions, less failures, access to the banking services	Financial inclusion
SHGs/NGOs/CSOs	Exclusion of the eligible women, lack of awareness, information gaps, digital barriers, lack of reliable data, implementation gaps, weak grievance	Inclusion of women in the programmes, better access to the govt schemes, opportunities	Community welfare
Taxpayers	Debt burden, opportunity cost of revenue expenditure	Efficient, accountable public spending	Long-run fiscal sustainability

Stakeholder Mapping: Power * Interest



Derived from the stated/unstated objectives

1. **Effectiveness:** Does the transfer actually improve the intended outcomes e.g. women's economic empowerment, financial self-reliance, Health and nutrition improvement, social standing of women
2. **Efficiency:** Does the scheme deliver enough benefit for the amount of money the government spends on it?
3. **Equity:** Are benefits reaching women who need them most? Are there exclusion/inclusion errors? Is a universal/unconditional design fair relative to a targeted one?
4. **Fiscal sustainability:** Can the government continue financing it without significantly crowding out other priority expenditure?
5. **Implementation/administrative feasibility:** Do eligible women access the transfer easily and reliably

Step 3: Evaluation of Criteria

Constitutional Values -

Non-discrimination and fundamental rights - Does the policy advance substantive equality for women? Article 15(3) permits the State to make special provisions for women and children.

Social and economic justice - Under the Directive Principles of State Policy (DPSP) article 38 directs the State to promote welfare and reduce inequalities. Does it reduce economic inequality or improve women's material security?

Takshashila core values -

Freedom: Does unconditional cash increase women's agency and ability to choose how money is spent, rather than the government dictating the use?

Pluralism: Does the scheme accommodate women with different household structures, occupations, communities and circumstances?

Realism: Is it fiscally and administratively sustainable given limited government resources and competing priorities?

Unconditional cash transfers to women broadly align with constitutional values of equality and social justice.

Scheme / State	Effectiveness (Outcomes)	Efficiency (Benefit/₹)	Equity (Targeting)	Fiscal sustainability (Pressure)	Administrative feasibility
Orunodoi / Assam	↑	?	↑	↔	↑
Mahtari Vandan / Chhattisgarh	?	?	↑	↓	↑
Delhi Lakshmi / Delhi	?	?	↑	?	?
Pyari Behna / Himachal Pradesh	?	?	↑	↓↓	?
Lado Lakshmi / Haryana	?	?	↑	↓	?
Maiyan Samman / Jharkhand	?	?	↔	↓↓	↑
Gruha Lakshmi / Karnataka	↑	?	↔	↓↓	↔
Majhi Ladki Bahin / Maharashtra	?	?	↓	↓	↓↓
Ladli Behna / Madhya Pradesh	?	?	↔	↓↓	↑
Subhadra / Odisha	?	?	↑	↓	↑
Magalir Urimai Thogai / Tamil Nadu	↑↑	?	↑	↓	↑
Lakshmir / Annapurna Bhandar / West Bengal	?	?	↔	↓↓	↑

↑↑ Strong positive
? Insufficient evidence

↑ Positive ↔ Mixed / neutral
NA Not applicable

↓ Concern ↓↓ Strong concern

Step 4: Economic Reasoning and Policy Analysis

No market failure is being addressed. The case for intervention is redistribution (a political preference), so the policy is better read as government failure.

1. Government failure

Market-failure test: no externality of meaningful size from health, education or productivity gains; unconditional cash is not a merit good; no public-good or monopoly problem.

What remains is a politically convenient instrument that substitutes for capital investment and structural reform in health, education and jobs.

2. Policy tool employed

Marginally changing incentives: a recurring cash subsidy to households.

Do-it-yourself: the state itself delivers, via DBT.

The household decides how to spend it, so the state fixes neither a service gap nor a price signal. Compare tools that act on the actual constraint: childcare, skilling, health services.

3. State capacity: strongest layer is used

STRONG: DBT delivery (Aadhaar, JAM, UPI)

WEAK:

- (i) beneficiary identification: 'woman head' rule, income certificates
- (ii) grievance redress
- (iii) fiscal forecasting
- (iv) independent evaluation

A cash tool relies on the strongest state layer, which is why it spreads. The services that would make it transformative rely on the weakest.

Expected Outcomes

Anticipated intended

1. Poverty reduction
2. Increase in women agency/empowerment
3. Economic development
4. Fiscal Sustainability
5. Household welfare
6. Intergenerational upliftment

Anticipated unintended negative

1. Transfer capture by male household members
2. Localised price inflation in supply-constrained markets
3. Reduced incentive to remain in low-paid formal work in marginal cases
4. Exclusion errors hitting the poorest (no bank access, no documents)
5. Political weaponization of eligibility criteria around election cycles
6. Erosion of state capacity for direct service delivery, as cash becomes the politically easier substitute

Theory of Change

Inputs	Activities	Outputs	Outcomes
Financial Capital State budget allocations. Treasury releases.	DBT transfer	Immediate Outputs Women receive monthly transfer. Bank accounts activated. Household liquidity increases. Digital transactions increase.	Medium-Term Outcomes Higher food expenditure. Better healthcare spending. Greater financial autonomy. Improved consumption smoothing.
Human Capital District administration. Panchayats. Bank correspondents. Anganwadi workers.	Subsidy		Long-Term Outcomes Poverty reduction. Human capital improvements. Women's bargaining power. Financial inclusion. Possible fiscal stress.
Material Infrastructure Aadhaar. NPCI. Banking network. Mobile connectivity.			

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